

Agri-environment heritage actions: value for nature and for people

Plain-English briefing demonstrator - June 2026 - The Tesseract Academy

About this briefing. A one-page accessible briefing demonstrator showing how we present heritage co-benefit evidence to a non-technical audience. Figures are drawn from published Natural England and Historic England sources. Designed to WCAG 2.2 AA principles (text alternatives, contrast, reading order).

Why heritage actions matter for nature and people

Heritage actions in farm schemes do more than protect the past. By managing historic features sensitively, they keep carbon locked in undisturbed soils, slow water run-off, support grassland biodiversity, sustain landscape character, and keep historic places legible and accessible for the people who live near and visit them. The same action delivers many benefits at once.

The headline evidence

- 75 per cent of Scheduled Monuments and all Registered Battlefields are on farmland.
- 84 per cent of Scheduled Monuments at Risk are on farmland; what threatens habitats also threatens heritage.
- Around 1,200 Scheduled Monuments have been removed from the Heritage at Risk Register with agri-environment support; heritage is managed across some 330,000 hectares.
- The heritage sector adds about 36.6 billion pounds to the economy each year; heritage visiting is estimated to save the NHS 193.2 million pounds; there are 1.25 million school visits to heritage sites a year.

The value-for-money point

When the multiple benefits of a heritage action are counted together (carbon, water, biodiversity, heritage and wellbeing) rather than a single outcome, the value-for-money case is stronger than a narrow view suggests. We value these benefits using the HM Treasury Green Book and Enabling a Natural Capital Approach. See our accompanying methodological demonstrator.